

Starting a newsletter was a gamble. But it wasn't exactly a step into the blue. He was familiar with direct-mail fundraising. Sending out direct-mail letters to get subscribers for his new newsletter was just "one step" away.

Still, it cost more to do his first marketing effort than he had in the bank. If it had not worked, he would have spent years paying off the debt. Fortunately, *International Living* was a success. It is still published today, from its headquarters in Ireland.

Thereafter, for the next 30-plus years, he took one step at a time, adding other publications, moving into the financial area, mastering the Internet, and building similar businesses in foreign countries.

The publishing industry suits us. In effect, we offer "outsider" ideas—on investment, health, and other subjects. There is no heavy lifting. It is not dangerous like truck driving or tedious like truck driving, or boring like truck driving, or dishonest like running the Fed.

We are writers at heart. It gives us a chance to write. We've been writing our financial blog, *The Daily Reckoning*, every day for over 12 years.

Of course, there were good times and bad times. Often, when we forgot the "one step at a time" rule, we lost money. Sometimes lots of money. We thought, for example, that we could turn a chateau in France into a conference center. Yes, in theory, it would work. But there were several giant steps required. We had to step across into a different culture and a different political and regulatory environment. We didn't know how to manage a conference center. We didn't know how to control the renovation. And then, we didn't know how to deal with the lawyers we brought into it to bring it under control.

Each error cost us heavily. It was a very expensive education. And since we had no desire to continue in that line of business, it was a tuition for no good reason.

Even in the publishing business, we lost money when we ventured out, taking more than one step at a time. Early on, for example, we thought we could make it in the magazine business. We published a magazine called *Frontiers of Science*.

The idea was not bad. But magazines are not newsletters. While newsletters are supposed to look amateurish, magazines are supposed to be slick and professional. And magazines require advertising; otherwise, the